

Getting Things Done Through myTinyTodo



This article covers myTinyTodo (MTT), a Getting Things Done (GTD) application.

Getting Things Done (GTD) by David Allen helps individuals manage tasks and remain productive in a stress-free manner. The key principle is to list all tasks and then process them according to their priority. Keeping all commitments in mind could distract one's focus on current activities. As the number of tasks increases, we develop stress and anxiety. With the modes of communication increasing day by day, the tasks we need to perform can originate from many places. Keeping track of all those tasks at one place and managing them continuously is the key to success.

"The ability to be successful, relaxed, and in control during these fertile but turbulent times demands new ways of thinking and working." – David Allen

There are many software tools available for task management and for to-do lists on PCs, mobile phones and the Web. Desktop-based to-do software on Linux include Getting Things GNOME, gToDo, and Emacs *org-mode*. Web-based to-do apps include Google Tasks and Remember the Milk. Mobile phone apps include Got To Do on Android, and Remember the Milk.

However, let us focus on the LAMP-powered browser-based task-management software myTinyTodo (MTT), which has all the features required to implement the GTD workflow. This open source tool has been developed by Max Pozdeev using PHP and jQuery, and is distributed under the GNU GPL. The tool can also be accessed using the browser on mobile phones since it supports small screens. Features include support for multiple lists, drag lists, tasks, tagging, prioritisation and search.

You can try the software online before installing it—play with the demo version at <http://mytinytodo.net/demo/>.

To install the software on Ubuntu, download the MTT zip files from <http://mytinytodo.net/>. Unzip the MTT zip file to the Web-root folder for your Web server software. In a browser, navigate to <http://localhost/mytinytodo>. You should see the following message displayed: Not installed. Run setup.php first. To the URL, add 'setup.php'. When this is run, the myTinyTodo 1.4.2 Setup asks you to choose between SQLite and MySQL databases. If you choose SQLite, ensure that the directory *mytinytodo/db* and the file *todoist.db* are writable by the user

account that your Web service runs under (e.g., *apache*). When the set-up is done, it prompts you to *Delete this file for security reasons*. In a terminal, rename *mytinytodo/setup.php* to *setup_orig.php* or give it a name of your choice, or move it to another folder out of the Web server root directory. Now, navigate your browser to <http://localhost/mytinytodo> to get started.

Putting GTD in use with MTT

MTT allows you to easily create tasks, add notes to tasks (for processing), organise tasks into groups, use tags to review through logical grouping, and finally mark the task as complete. These five steps map to the workflow defined in GTD.

5-Stage Workflow	MTT actions
Collect	Create tasks by just giving a title to each.
Process	Add notes on inputs required and the next actions to perform.
Organise	Group each task after processing into the task list, represented by tabs in the tool.
Review	Review periodically—to do or dump.
Do	Mark the task as complete when done.

"We need to transform all the 'stuff' we're trying to organise into actionable stuff we need to do." – David Allen

Create these tabs in MTT: **INBOX**, **ACTIONABLES** and **SOMEDAY**. Here is the purpose of each list:

- **INBOX:** Collect all tasks you need to complete; "blindly" take note of the task, without thought on whether it needs you to work on it or not. After the complete list is captured, review and process tasks. Any task that needs an action from you, or is to be delegated to someone will move to the ACTIONABLES list. You move tasks from one tab to another by clicking the triangle that appears at the end of each task row (see Figure 1). You should immediately complete tasks that can be done in two minutes, and mark them closed by checking the box.
- **ACTIONABLES:** This task list could have a due date and also